

ICICI BANK'S METEORIC RISE

ICICI Bank, under Sandeep Bakhshi, has left behind bellwethers like HUL and Infosys to climb two positions on this year's *BT500* list and break into the Top 5

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FIVE YEARS AGO, Bhadohi in Uttar Pradesh—around 50 km from Varanasi—was a sleepy town, with its hand-woven carpets being its only claim to fame. Small carpet-weaving units were scattered

across the region, some struggling to survive while new ones emerged every year. The double jolt from demonetisation and the roll-out of GST also cast a shadow on the economy of this town in southern Uttar Pradesh. As the dust settled, the implementation of GST became a catalyst for the formalisation of the industry. Several fintech and smaller NBFC players descended upon Bhadohi to offer cash-flow lending—which is based on daily earnings instead of balance sheet-based lending—to those who were unbanked and underbanked.

Fast forward to today, and the economy of Bhadohi has taken a new turn. Those once modest

mom-and-pop units have evolved into thriving small and medium enterprises (SMEs), thanks to formal credit lines. Bhadohi has also established a foothold in the international carpets market, commanding half of the country's export of carpets. And one of the lenders that tapped Bhadohi at the right time is ICICI Bank, the country's second-largest private bank by assets. The micro-markets team at the lender kept a close eye on the town's progress and established branches and specialised staff to meet its banking requirements. The micro-markets strategy, spearheaded by Sandeep Bakhshi, MD & CEO of ICICI Bank, is a part of the half-a-dozen value